Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Denise Lermontov's "Making Peace"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in discussing the speaker's argument that both peace and poetry are made of words and that the poet can both affect the world and effect change include

alliteration,
analogy,
anaphora,
contrast,
controlling image,
diction,
figurative language,
free verse,
imagery,
metaphor,
sigmatism,
simile,
speaker,
symbol,
theme, and
tone.

Noting that Lermontov's second stanza posits that the making of peace and the making of poems are both processes, the young literary critic might argue that the "different fulcrum" (line 23) that is "the restructur[ing of] the sentence our lives are making" (18) is, indeed, central to the comparison that Lermontov has set up in line 6's "But peace, like a poem [. . .]."

The contestant might focus on imagination (lines 3, 4, 8) as a conceptual notion underlying both the making of peace and the making of poetry.

The student might recognize that the last stanza's move from the ambiguity of peace having "weight" (line 22) toward the speaker's analogy that peace has/is a "presence" (23) and that "each act of living" is within a stanza comprised of words as "vibrations of light" (26-29)—a move that might be recognized as a move beyond the structured process of sentence construction that is reliant on grammar and syntax, even if of "justice" and "mutual aid," respectively (11-12), toward something with "an energy field more intense than war" (24) somehow symbolized—poetically—in a multifaceted crystal.

The student looking for a connection might find it in John Lennon's "Imagine," in which the constructs nationhood, religion, and property rights are displaced by the imagination's ability to rewrite the world's sentence.